historical, and transnational perspectives evident in this complex and evolving blockade. The Berlin Wall signified both a fortified border and a geopolitical crossroad, a space where the past protruded into the present and brought to light the mechanics of geopolitical division.

From its beginning, the physical presence of the Berlin Wall amplified its symbolic power. Frederick Taylor and Brian Ladd, among others, powerfully remind us that the name "Berlin Wall" never referred to a single wall but, rather, to a broader system of border fortifications limiting access to the formerly free city of Berlin that was later heavily policed and regulated. The Wall always operated on both physical and symbolic terms and, as Ladd notes, "came to signify all the consequences of the division of Berlin and all of Europe."[12] The structure was a tangible barrier in a conflict of Cold War ideologies in a city that evoked deep American identifications and attachments.

Cold War Berlin was a major focal point of political confrontation, military occupation, and cultural connection. The American public's fascination with the city's walled border was connected to Berlin's defense and to the spectacle of the Berlin Wall. The United States did not build the Wall. But the construction of a fortified border in divided Berlin by East Germany not only bisected the city but also ran within footsteps of its occupied American sector and (symbolically, if not politically) U.S. soil. The expansion of popular American media and consumer spheres of the 1960s coincided with the dramatic images and footage of Berlin's emergent wall, including the option to view the border crisis on network television, as well as on other cultural platforms, including film, popular music, print media, and art venues. This was the case in August 1961, when NBC's *Jack Paar Show* filmed an on-site episode at the Wall days after its initial construction, prompting Senate Democratic majority leader Mike Mansfield to share his view on the floor of Congress: "One would hope that the Berlin Wall, where so much is at stake for this Nation, does not now become the new Mecca for the jaded of the entertainment world."[13] His discouragement was not enough, however, to deter such critical energies and breakdowns of official order at the border. For example, as Penny Von Eschen details, when Louis "Satchmo" Armstrong played a 1965 concert in East Berlin's Friedrichstadt Plaza, he managed to cross the border to West Berlin at Checkpoint Charlie without proper credentials, after East German and